Grey in cultures and traditions

Grey is a colour people long thought of as "without meaning". Stone, mist, metal. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about craft, faith and power than about the colour itself**. Let us visit a few places and read them carefully.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how grey is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as instructions. What is verified history and what is later interpretation, I say in each part.

Grey in different cultures

Japan

In the Edo period the shogunate restricted luxury for people outside the ruling class. The outer layers of clothing could only be in muted grey, brown and navy. According to an exhibition at the Honolulu museum there were **over a hundred variants** of these shades.

The restriction became a game. The people of Edo wore colourful patterned fabrics on linings and underwear and on visible layers they invented stripes.

Grey here is not a lack. It is **the colour of a taste that does not need to show itself**.

China

Chinese ink painting, shuimo hua, arose under the Tang dynasty (618 to 907) and flourished under the Song dynasty (960 to 1279). A painter can pass from a single brush stroke from deep black to silvery grey, depending on how thickly the ink was spread and how hard he pressed.

This style reached Japan in the fourteenth century through Zen monasteries. Zen links it with calm and simplicity.

Grey here is not what is left of colour. It is **a whole scale from which a landscape is born**.

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Iceland

Icelandic sheep are born black, grey, brown and white and undyed wool in these shades is in demand. From wool called lopi, lopapeysa jumpers are knitted. According to the knitting historian Annemor Sundbø the pattern is related to a 1930 model and after 1944, when Iceland gained full independence, it became a national symbol.

From Nordic cold, where grey is not a restriction but the natural colour of an animal.

A colour can be **a material that does not need dyeing** to be valuable.

Peru

The Incas built their most sacred structures, such as the Temple of the Sun at Machu Picchu, from precisely cut stones that fitted together without mortar. The walls sloped slightly inward and had rounded corners, and therefore resisted earthquakes well. In strong tremors the blocks, as described, "danced" and then returned to place.

From architecture that reckons with the earth moving.

Grey here is not dead. It is **stone that has learned to stand in motion**.

Grey in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at grey **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing manual.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the classical system of five elements white is linked mainly with metal. **Grey has no organ circuit of its own.** In some extended colour interpretations it comes close to metal through the look of metallic materials and its kinship with white. In the traditional metal circuit autumn, lungs, large intestine and grief meet. These are connections within a traditional system, not a guide to determining health by clothing.

How it relates to grey. Autumn can offer an image of discernment. What to keep and what you no longer need to carry. Perhaps you have at home things you did not choose, tasks nobody else took over, and ideas about yourself that long ago stopped fitting. You do not have to throw everything out. **You can start with one place.**

And what if I asked you now?

“What do I need to put down today to make more room?”

A grey base on the table

Try a simple grey base on the table and keep on it only what you are currently doing. The benefit can be fewer things competing for attention.

In grief

A surrounding that does not ask for a cheerful expression may feel pleasant. Grey can accompany this need. You do not have to get orange curtains just to show that you are "moving on". But notice the difference between pleasant privacy and a surrounding in which you feel increasingly lonely.

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to grey. Ayurvedic thinking works with the qualities of warmth and cold, lightness and heaviness or movement and stability. Grey, though, is not always equally cold or heavy. A soft woollen blanket and a glossy metal chair may be a similar colour and have a completely different relation to your comfort.

Pitta

This describes a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, who flares up easily. A light, cooler grey can feel cooling and calming. Glossy metal and sharp contrast may, on the contrary, irritate.

- **Dove and silver**
  Light and cooling, as a base.
- **Beware of sharp contrast**
  Black with glossy metal can be one more stimulus.

Vata

This describes a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold. A warmer grey-beige and soft fabrics can add warmth. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Grey-beige and wool**
  Warm and soft, without chill.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Soft textiles and warm light.

Kapha

This describes a woman who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily grows heavy. Large dark grey areas can deepen the heaviness, so give them **a lively and light companion**.

- **Light wood and colour**
  A fresh counterweight.
- **Add movement**
  Yellow or orange as an accent. A scarf, a tablecloth.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe grey as a colour of its own. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thinking, not his statement.

How it relates to grey. Grey lies between white and black, that is, between light and dark. In symbolic language you can read it as **the colour of the threshold and of the space between two poles**. When you think about it, ask where you stand between two possibilities and whether that threshold serves you.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours turned into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same grey can be calm for one woman and coldness for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic frame, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging space so that it is good to live in. In some contemporary schools grey belongs to metal and the themes of clarity, lucidity and order. Schools differ in the assignments, so take it as one possibility.

Grey is like silver

A little gives a space clarity, a whole room turns it into a catalogue. Order is not the number of grey things.

Simple tips

- **Start with a question**
  Does simplicity help me, or did I remove from the room even what I love? The difference is often in the light.
- **Try a warmer fabric**
  A soft throw or a linen cushion softens a cold impression better than another grey decoration.
- **Vary the surfaces**
  Smooth and textured grey work together better than five identical surfaces.
- **Add light**
  Grey without daylight feels empty. Draw back the curtains and let the light in.
- **Watch the undertones**
  Warm grey-beige and cold blue-grey sometimes understand each other less than their shared name promised.
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a room, try a throw or a larger sample and look at it both in the morning and in the evening.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Grey is dull.

TRUTH Photographers use a grey card with 18 percent reflectance as a reference for exposure and white balance. Grey is there actually a fixed point.

MYTH Grey always calms.

TRUTH Warm grey does. Cold grey without daylight can feel oppressive. Wood, linen or one warm colour will help.

MYTH Grey goes with everything.

TRUTH Mostly yes, but it depends on the undertone. A bluish grey next to warm wood can be cold. Hold a sample against your things and look at it in daylight.

What grey goes well with

- **Wood, ochre and terracotta**
  A warmer, earthier impression.
- **Pink**
  Softness or striking contrast depending on the shade.
- **Yellow**
  A conspicuous light accent.
- **Green**
  A pairing recalling leaves and stone.
- **Blue**
  A cooler whole. Watch the light and the amount of both colours.
- **White and black**
  More pronounced differences between surfaces.

Elements

- **Metal**
  Grey is its natural stand-in. Make sure it does not outweigh.
- **Earth**
  Ochre and stone warm it up.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.
- **Fire**
  Warm light and a small red accent heat it up.

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Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. A grey sofa can let a picture, wood, plants or a favourite textile stand out.

What to watch for. When the floor, wall, sofa and curtains are all grey, the individual parts blend, especially in a room with little light.

A simple tip. Try a warmer fabric, a lighter surface or a colour you like.

Kitchen and bathroom

What works. Grey cupboards, stone or tiles can feel pleasant.

What to watch for. More glossy grey surfaces and cold light, the result is then austere.

A simple tip. Wood, textiles or coloured ceramics change the reflections and the feel of the materials.

Bedroom

What works. A warm light grey can be pleasant on bedding or a wall. With cream, muted pink or wood it feels softer than blue-grey with metal.

What to watch for. Cold grey and shine. A shade you liked in the shop may look different at home.

A simple tip. If you feel cold, start with textiles and light. You do not have to repaint the whole room at once.

Children's room

What works. A grey base allows easy changing of pictures and textiles.

What to watch for. An adult's taste is not automatically a child's need.

A simple tip. Let the child choose. A room can be tidy and still have an orange dinosaur in it.

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Study

What works. Grey can create an unobtrusive background on which work stands out.

What to watch for. A large dark area can needlessly darken the space. A pleasant shade does not replace a good lamp.

A simple tip. Add something of your own too. A study need not look as if you had rented it together with someone else's life.

Hallway and street

What works. You walk down a street and it seems sad to you. Is it only the grey, or also that there is no tree or bench anywhere and the houses are neglected? A few streets further there may be a stone square, also grey, but with trees and people.

What to watch for. Claiming that a grey city is sad, regardless of light and greenery.

A simple tip. On a walk try to notice two grey places, one pleasant and one you want to get away from. What is different?

And try answering now

"Why do I want grey at home? What should it bring me, calm, clarity, or space for myself?"

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